



CREAF CoARA ACTION PLAN 2024-2029



This Plan has been approved by Joan Pino, the Director of CREAM, and takes effect from 30/11/24. This Plan will be reviewed and updated every 5 years.

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INTRODUCTION

The evolving landscape of research assessment methodologies and the growing prominence of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) urges CREAM to align its institutional policies and strategies with CoARA in its global effort to enhance the fairness, transparency, and effectiveness of research assessment practices.

Moreover, recent developments of the Catalan and Spanish scientific policies and regulations, including academic assessment, drive institutions to undergo changes to respond to the new national requirements. The main developments are those introduced by RD 678/2023, the Organic Law on Universities (LOSU), the Law on Science, Technology and Innovation (LCTI) and the National Strategy for Open Science (ENCA) all of which promote open science, a diversification of evaluation criteria and a revised recognition and reward framework. Moreover, the National Agency for Quality Assessment and Accreditation of Spain (ANECA) adhered to DORA and CoARA and initiated the consequent reforms of its assessment exercises. The first step made by ANECA was the establishment of a Commission (where CREAM participates) to design an ex-ante evaluation proposal regarding the adaptation of the research evaluation system (criteria, indicators, sources, etc.) used in ANECA's teaching staff accreditation programs. Additionally, the Catalan Science Law (2022) and the Catalan Strategic Plan for Innovation and Knowledge Transfer (2023) stress the commitment for Open Science and wider perspectives in research evaluation.

Taking into consideration the national context and as a signatory of the CoARA agreement, CREAM commits to the dual objective of upholding rigorous and transparent standards for research evaluation, and promoting an organizational culture of integrity, collaboration, openness, and innovation.

This action plan outlines strategic steps to ensure that CREAM's policies and practices are harmonized with CoARA's recommendations, thereby advancing the collective mission of promoting high-quality research and supporting a positive research culture.

CREAM's assessment processes –currently directed towards the recruitment and promotion of researchers– should concentrate on valuing knowledge, societal relevance and research environment as key dimensions. Moreover, they should encourage experimentation, creativity and a 'publish for purpose' spirit, contributing to reversing the academic pressure to produce.

Designing a renewed approach to assess research at CREAM is part of a cultural shift. To ensure changes are successfully and widely adopted, they need to be relevant and rooted within the community. In this sense, the design of this action plan has included engagement activities such as public consultations and targeted meetings to involve researchers across all career stages and research management staff.

THE 10 COMMITMENTS OF THE COARA AGREEMENT

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes.
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes, as well as their use.
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments.
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

ACTION PLAN

1. INSTITUTIONAL AND SYSTEM ENGAGEMENT

- 1.1. Set up an institutional working group of researchers and research managers to design, implement, evaluate and develop CREAM CoARA Action Plan.
- 1.2. Conduct a thorough review of existing research policies to identify areas that are to be aligned with CoARA principles, challenges and opportunities.
- 1.3. Establish internal communications to disseminate CoARA principles and CREAM CoARA Action Plan to CREAM members (researchers, technical staff and research managers).
- 1.4. Define communication actions to give visibility to CREAM CoARA Action Plan and commitments externally through institutional social media channels, the website, etc.
- 1.5. Engage with CoARA working groups, the Spanish national chapter and/or general assembly as appropriate to support the systemic reform, exchange good practices, and monitor global progress.

2. TRAINING AND RESOURCES

- 2.1. Organize a general training-awareness session on CoARA principles.
- 2.2. Develop the necessary resources to implement reforms, such as guidance documents or training for those involved in:
 - Open access publishing, FAIR and open data management, and reproducible research practices.
 - Societal impact and open engagement of societal actors and citizens in research.
 - Opening dialogue and collaboration with other disciplines and knowledge systems.
 - Research ethics and integrity.
 - Approaches of broader assessment (e.g., narrative CV for researchers or equivalent)

3. RESPONSIBLE ASSESSMENT

- 3.1. Redesign CREAM's promotion policy.
- 3.2. Design CREAM's researchers' recruitment and recognition procedures.
- 3.3. Promote an annual assessment of CREAM's researchers' performance.
- 3.4. Conduct a pilot test of a selected recruitment process to evaluate and refine the new assessment system.

Actions 3.1., 3.2., and 3.3. will be aligned with the following principles:

- Transparency of the assessment process (e.g., protocols published on the intranet, OTM-R policy KPI regularly published, etc.).
- Avoid inappropriate uses of rankings and metrics, especially those based on journals such as the Journal Impact Factor and the h-index.
- Stimulate and reward diverse outputs (such as publications, articles deposited in a publicly available preprint server, books, book chapters, conference proceedings, data sets, software, patents, licenses, standards, start-up businesses, etc.), practices (inter and multidisciplinary, participatory research, etc.) and activities (engagement with stakeholders, etc.) throughout the whole research process and across all career levels.
- Encourage the use of narratives and evidence-based CVs to contextualize the quality and relevance of academic contributions and future research plans.
- Include mobilisation of research knowledge and societal impact of research.
- Reward open engagement of societal actors.
- Reward leadership and team spirit skills.
- Reward researchers who adopt and advocate for open science practices as defined in CREAM Open Science Policy.
- Ensure a diverse range of profiles and composition in evaluation committees.
- Ensure transparency regarding the assessment criteria and the outcome of the selection process.

4. OPEN SCIENCE AND KNOWLEDGE MANAGEMENT

Build upon CREAM's strategic commitment to the Open Science movement channelled through a newly created position to:

4.1. Embed OS principles in existing and new institutional policies and protocols, building on international and national frameworks on open and responsible science practices, balancing openness with data security, privacy and intellectual property rights, protection of commercial secrets, protection of endangered species or biodiversity, etc.

4.2. Offer and promote dedicated infrastructure. This includes implementing a CRIS system, encouraging the use of institutional or external trusted tools, publishing platforms and repositories, reducing dependency of proprietary databases in favour of open-source alternatives, and balancing qualitative information and informetrics to assess research contributions.

4.3. Design a service catalogue to support researchers in adopting open science practices.

4.4. Design internal campaigns that foster the uptake of the open science model throughout the research lifecycle.

5. RESEARCH ETHICS AND INTEGRITY

5.1. Design a research integrity promotion plan.

5.2. Establish procedures to handle ethical and integrity dilemmas, questionable practices (e.g., failing to keep accurate records of the research process, excessive paper retractions and self-citations) and misconduct (e.g., data fabrication, false affiliations).

5.3. Establish a code of good practices for supervision.

5.4. Promote a regular mentoring program for early-career researchers.

6. MONITORING AND EVALUATION

6.1. Conduct regular implementation progress reviews of the CREAM CoARA Action Plan to ensure objectives are being met effectively.

6.2. Share regular internal updates on progress with staff to promote transparency.

ACTION	TIMEFRAME	COORDINATOR	ASSESSMENT METHOD
1 INSTITUTIONAL AND SYSTEM ENGAGEMENT Related CoARA Commitments: 5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to. 7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes, as well as their use. 8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.			
1.1. Establish an institutional working group of researchers and research managers to design, implement, evaluate and develop CREAM CoARA Action Plan	T3 2024	CREAF's Direction	Establishment of the working group
1.2. Conduct a thorough review of existing research policies to identify areas that are to be aligned with CoARA principles, challenges and opportunities	T1 2025	CoARA WG	Report with policies reviewed
1.3. Establish internal communications to make CoARA Principles and CREAM CoARA Action Plan known to CREAM members	2024-2029	CoARA WG Communication Dept.	Number of internal communications
1.4. Define external communication actions to give visibility to CREAM CoARA Action Plan and Commitment	2024-2029	CoARA WG Communication Dept.	Number of external communications
1.5. Engage with CoARA working groups, the Spanish national chapter and/or general assembly	2024-2029	Research Impact officer	Number of CoARA- related groups/initiatives

		Academic Talent and EDI officer	with CREAM's participation
2 TRAINING AND RESOURCES Related CoARA Commitments: 7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.			
2.1. Organize a general training-awareness session on CoARA principles	T2 2025 T2 2027	Academic Talent and EDI officer and Research Impact officer	Number of participants in the session
2.2. Develop the necessary resources to implement reforms, such as guidance documents or trainings	2026-2027	Research Management Offices	List of accessible trainings, materials and tools
3 RESPONSIBLE ASSESSMENT Related CoARA Commitments: 1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research. 2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators. 3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index. 4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment. 6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes.			
3.1. Redesign CREAM's promotion policy and procedures	2025-2026	CoARA WG	Reviewed promotion policy and procedures
3.2. Design CREAM's researchers' recruitment and recognition procedures	2025-2026	CoARA WG	Reviewed recruitment and recognition policy and procedures
3.3. Promote an annual assessment of CREAM's researchers' performance	2026	CREAM's Direction	Annual assessment report

4 OPEN SCIENCE AND KNOWLEDGE MANAGEMENT

Related CoARA Commitments:

5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.

10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

4.1. Embed OS principles in existing and new institutional policies and protocols	2024-2029	Open Science and Knowledge Manager	List of policies and protocols
4.2. Offer and promote dedicated infrastructure, including a CRIS system and official repositories	2024-2029	Open Science and Knowledge Manager	List of infrastructures
4.3. Design a service catalog to support researchers in adopting open science practices	T1 2025	Open Science and Knowledge Manager	Service catalog
4.4. Design internal campaigns that foster open science practices throughout the research lifecycle	2025-2029	Open Science and Knowledge Manager	List of internal communications

5 RESEARCH ETHICS AND INTEGRITY

Related CoARA Commitments:

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.

10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

5.2. Design a research integrity promotion plan	T4 2024	CoARA WG	Research integrity promotion plan
5.3. Establish procedures to handle ethical and integrity dilemmas, questionable practices and misconduct	2027	CoARA WG	Procedures for the management of suspected scientific misconduct
5.4. Establish a code of good practices for supervision	2029	Academic Talent and EDI officer	Code of good practices for supervision
5.5. Promote a regular mentoring program for early-career researchers	2028-2029	Academic Talent and EDI officer	Mentoring programs conducted and number of participants

6 MONITORING AND EVALUATION

Related CoARA Commitments:

9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments.

10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

6.1. Conduct regular implementation progress reviews of the CREAM CoARA Action Plan to ensure objectives are being met effectively.	T4 2025, T4 2026, T4 2027, T4 2028, T4 2029	CoARA WG	Annual progress reports
6.2. Share regular internal updates on progress to promote transparency.	T4 2025, T4 2026, T4 2027, T4 2028, T4 2029	CoARA WG	Annual internal communication